B2 Grammar

Reported speech

Report statements, questions and requests, and know when the tense moves back.

We use reported speech to tell someone what another person said. With a past reporting verb such as *said* or *asked*, the verb in the reported part usually moves one step back in time.

Direct speech	Reported speech
"I'm tired."	*She said (that) she was tired.*
"We'll call you."	*They said they would call me.*
"I've finished."	*He said he had finished.*
"I saw it yesterday."	*She said she had seen it the day before.*
"I can help."	*He said he could help.*

Questions

Yes/no questions take *if* or *whether*. Wh- questions keep the question word. Both use statement word order, with no *do*, *does* or *did*.

Direct question	Reported question
"Are you ready?"	*He asked if I was ready.*
"Where do you live?"	*She asked where I lived.*

Requests and orders

Use *ask* or *tell* + person + *to* + verb. For negatives, put *not* before *to*.

Direct	Reported
"Please sit down."	*He asked me to sit down.*
"Don't be late."	*She told us not to be late.*

Time and place words

Direct	Reported
now	then, at that time
today / tonight	that day / that night
tomorrow	the next day, the following day
yesterday	the day before, the previous day
here / this	there / that

No backshift needed. If something is still true when you report it, you can keep the original tense: *He said the meeting is on Friday* (and it still is).

Common mistakes. Do not keep question order: *She asked where did I live* is wrong; say *She asked where I lived*. And *tell* needs a person: *He told me he was leaving*, but *He said he was leaving*.

Practice

1. "I'm working from home today," Sara said.
2. "Have you seen my keys?" he asked me.
3. "Where is the station?" the tourist asked.
4. "Don't touch the screen," the teacher told us.
5. "We will finish the report tomorrow," they said.
6. Choose: He (said / told) me that he was leaving.

▼ **Show answers**

1. Sara said she was working from home that day.
2. He asked me if I had seen his keys.
3. The tourist asked where the station was.
4. The teacher told us not to touch the screen.
5. They said they would finish the report the next day.
6. told